



WHAT'S SUPER IN A SUPERCOMPUTER?

We have all heard of supercomputers. But do you know where they are used and how they compute, and what the latest developments are in the world of quantum thought?

Supercomputers have come a long way since they first came on the scene. Their ability to perform a large number of complex calculations at speeds that were hitherto unheard of have found them several uses. Supercomputers are now being used in fields like economics, biology, astrophysics, Artificial Intelligence and many others. They have played a crucial role in the advancement of knowledge and the quality of life. But where did it all begin?

It all began with Cray

Way back in 1960, after starting his Control Data Corp. (CDC), Seymour Cray began designing a system that was to be the first supercomputer, the CDC 6600. This was also the first to employ

three-dimensional packaging and an instruction set that was later referred to as RISC (Reduced Instruction Set Computer). Cray realised that merely improving clock speed would not improve computation speed in any way. He anticipated the need for parallelism in computation and came up with the CDC 8600 which had four processors, all sharing the same memory. Since developing necessary software at the time was no simple matter, Cray suggested that vector capabilities be built on uniprocessors, which would improve the performance greatly. Cray Research, a division of CDC, came up with Cray-1, Cray-2, Cray-3 and Cray-4.

Cray-3 and Cray-4 worked at clock speeds of 500 MHz and 1GHz—all this in 1994 when no

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Sources: AV Max Annual Awards November 2000 (53 inch Flatscreen category)